

Digital Governance and E-Administration — E-Administration Framework

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The E-Administration Framework describes how universities will digitalise records management, administrative processes and citizen-facing services. It sets out the approach, the roles involved and the standards institutions must meet to deliver effective digital governance.

1. Background

Administrative work in universities remains largely paper-based in many areas, leading to delays, duplication and difficulty retrieving information. At the same time, students and staff increasingly expect digital services that are simple, fast and reliable. This framework responds to these pressures by setting out a planned route to digitalise core administrative functions while maintaining the integrity of records and processes.

The framework is informed by the lessons of recent digital transitions, international good practice in e-governance, and the specific needs of university administration.

2. Purpose

The purpose of this framework is to provide a common reference for the planning, implementation and governance of e-administration across universities. It does not prescribe a single technology solution, but sets out the functional expectations, governance principles and oversight arrangements that institutions must meet.

3. Objectives

- Establish a records management system that ensures the authenticity, retrievability and secure retention of administrative documents.
- Digitise high-volume, transactional services (registration, certification, fees, HR) to reduce processing time and improve the user experience.
- Create a common data architecture for administrative information so that decisions are based on reliable, shared data.
- Improve access to services through online portals and self-service tools.

- Strengthen data protection and access security for administrative records.
- Build institutional capacity for digital governance through roles, training and change support.

4. Scope

This framework covers the administrative services of universities, their affiliated colleges and relevant directorate offices. It applies to records management, transactional services and the supporting data architecture. Academic delivery and learning management systems are covered by other policies.

5. Guiding Principles

- Service orientation: digital governance is designed around the needs of students and staff, not internal process convenience.
- Integrity: administrative records must remain authentic, complete and secure throughout their lifecycle.
- Interoperability: systems must be able to share data securely and efficiently with other approved systems.
- Transparency: users should be able to track the status of their transactions.
- Accountability: clear roles and audit trails must support good governance.
- Sustainability: solutions must be maintainable within institutional capacity and budgets.

6. Service Digitisation Approach

6.1 Prioritisation

Universities should prioritise services by transaction volume, user impact and readiness. Common first priorities include student registration, fee payment, certificate requests, leave and attendance for staff, and examination administration.

6.2 Portal and Self-Service

Students and staff should access services through a central portal that provides a single sign-on, status tracking and a history of transactions. Self-service tools should be simple, accessible and supported by clear guidance.

6.3 Workflow Design

Digital workflows should reduce manual intervention, automate approvals where appropriate, and create a clear audit trail. Exceptions and escalations must be defined for every workflow.

7. Records and Information Management

All universities must adopt a records management standard that covers creation, classification, retention, retrieval and disposal. Records must be stored in open, long-lived formats. A classification scheme approved by the records governance officer must be implemented. Annual records audits must confirm the completeness and accessibility of the digital record.

8. Data Architecture and Governance

Universities should define core data domains (student, staff, finance, estate) and assign clear ownership for each. Data shared between systems must be reconciled against master sources. A minimum data quality standard must be published, and data issues must be logged and resolved within defined timelines.

9. Security and Access Control

Administrative systems must implement role-based access control. Users must authenticate through strong credentials, and access rights must be reviewed periodically. Sensitive records must be encrypted in transit and at rest. Security incidents must be reported to the university's information security lead and, where significant, to the department.

10. Service Levels and Reporting

Each university must publish service level expectations for major administrative transactions, including turnaround times and escalation paths. Performance against these levels must be monitored and reported to the university administration at least quarterly.

11. Governance and Oversight

A university-level Digital Governance Board must oversee implementation, approve standards, resolve data disputes and review risks. The board should include representation from academic administration, finance, IT and the student body.

12. Implementation Support and Incentives

The University Administration will support institutions through technical guidance, shared tools and recognition of good practice. Implementation grants may be offered where appropriate to accelerate adoption in resource-constrained institutions.

13. Review

This framework will be reviewed every three years, or sooner if technology, regulatory or institutional circumstances require it. Institutions are encouraged to contribute case studies and evidence to the review process.

14. Contact

Institutions seeking guidance on implementation should contact the University Administration's governance and digital services division through the HEIRS portal.